

Title

Snapd ESM tracks for Ubuntu Core

Type	Author(s)	Status	Created
Implementation ▾	Alfonso Sanchez-Be...	Braindump ▾	Mar 30, 2026
	Reviewer(s)	Status	Date
	Samuele Pedroni	Pending Review ▾	📅 Date
	Ernest Lotter	Pending Review ▾	📅 Date
	Nick Dyer	Approved ▾	📅 Date
	Maciej Borzęcki	Approved ▾	23 Apr 2026

Abstract

This specification defines how we will use snapd tracks to support Ubuntu Core (UC) versions when they reach the Expanded Security Maintenance (ESM) stage.

Rationale

As UC versions are maintained more and more years, there is a significant maintenance burden for snapd. Here we introduce ESM tracks for the snapd snap to reduce the maintenance effort so new features do not need to be supported in older snapd and so we can remove code that is applicable only to older UC versions. This also reduces the chances of regressions in older versions as snapd changes for them are minimized.

Specification

SnapD will have a map of ESM UC versions to snapd tracks. This will be updated when it is decided that a new snapd version is going to be the ESM version for a given UC release.

On installation/refresh:

- SnapD will find the UC release from the model. This will be a number matching the

- boot base (18, 20, etc. - note that this is not related to the snapd snap build base, but to the running UC version)
- This will be combined with the current risk level and branch for SnapD, for example:
 - 18/stable
 - 22/edge/branch (if the device is tracking a SnapD branch)
 - If a snapd version that is unaware of the ESM track of the running UC version refreshes to one that is (or this one that is aware is started on installation), this snapd will switch to the ESM track and refresh to the snapd found there. This will happen in the same change by the new snapd inserting tasks as it starts to run.
 - If we are using an unasserted snapd snap in UC ESM, an “amend” will allow only using the track of the snapd ESM version. Unasserted snapd snaps will not perform this check.

Any model assertion that specifies “default-channel: latest/<track>” will be interpreted by the corresponding ESM snapd version (or higher version) as “default-channel: <UC_version>/<track>”, so model assertions signed before this change are still valid. This will apply when creating images and when performing a remodel.

For UC versions that have not reached ESM, it will not be possible to use tracks different to “latest”, to make it possible to remove older code useful only for ESM releases. For UC with a snapd ESM version, it will not be possible to switch to a track that is not for their ESM.

This locks down the tracks for the snapd snap to be used to specify only the UC version. If we want a snapd track for something else, we need to define new behavior for the track names decided in this specification. This will happen eventually for FIPS.

Further Information

[1] [UCXXX - Ubuntu Core Support Process](#)

Spec History and Changelog

Author(s)	Status	Date	Comment
 Person	Braindump ▾	 Date	Brain dump
 Person	Drafting ▾	 Date	Initial review, comments
 Person	Pending Review ▾	 Date	